

FIVE ROUTES • ONE ISLAND

Mapping Northern Cyprus, *one drive at a time.*

Five self-drive routes, west to east, each built from real stops and the kind of tips you'd only get from someone who has already made the trip.

5

routes submitted

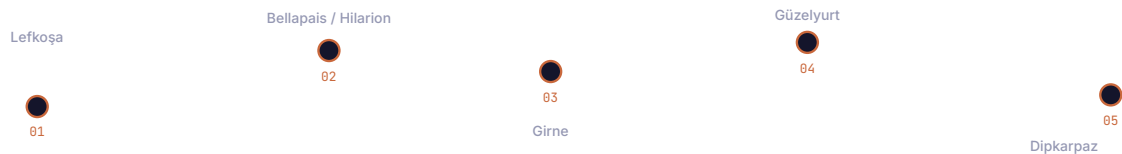
26

stops mapped

1

island, corner to corner

THE ROUTE, LAID FLAT



ROUTE 01 • LEFKOŞA (NICOSIA)

Old city culture *& street walk.*

Walking route · walled city centre

Lefkoşa's old town is the last divided capital in Europe, and its walled centre is small enough to cross on foot in an afternoon. This route moves through the Venetian gates, the Ottoman market halls, and the quiet residential quarters where the city's daily life still happens behind stone walls.

1

Kyrenia Gate

The old Venetian-era gate marking the historic entrance into the walled city from the north.

2

Büyük Han

A restored 16th-century Ottoman caravanserai, now filled with craft workshops and a courtyard café.

3

Selimiye Mosque

A former Gothic cathedral converted centuries ago, its twin minarets rise above the old city rooftops.

4

Bandabuliya Municipal Market

A covered Ottoman-era market hall, now home to produce stalls, spice sellers, and small eateries.

5

Arabahmet Quarter

An old Ottoman residential district of restored stone houses and quiet cobbled lanes.

6

Samanbahçe

Cyprus's first social housing project, rows of small traditional houses still lived in today.

Practical info: allow 2–3 hours on foot, best walked in the morning before the heat. Wear flat shoes for cobblestones. Some streets run close to the buffer zone — carry ID if you plan to cross south.

LOCAL TIP

Bandabuliya's produce stalls are cheapest right at opening — before the tour groups arrive around mid-morning.

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ROUTE 02 • KYRENIA MOUNTAINS

Bellapais Abbey *& St. Hilarion views.*

Drive + short hikes · mountain range above Kyrenia

This route climbs from a hillside village into the Kyrenia mountain range, ending at a fortress with the best view on the island. It's short in distance but slow in pace — the kind of route built around stopping, not driving through.

1

Bellapais Village

A hillside village overlooking Kyrenia, with narrow lanes, small galleries, and shaded cafés.

2

Bellapais Abbey

13th-century Gothic abbey ruins, one of the most photographed sites in Northern Cyprus.

3

Karmi Village

A restored stone village popular with resident artists, with small galleries tucked into old houses.

4

St. Hilarion Castle

A Byzantine mountain fortress with sweeping views over the entire Kyrenia coastline.

5

Ilgaz Pass viewpoint

A roadside stop on the mountain pass with views over both the north and south coasts at once.

Practical info: a car is needed for the mountain sections. The castle climb takes 30–40 minutes on uneven steps. Late afternoon light is best for photos and is noticeably cooler.

LOCAL TIP

Bellapais Abbey's courtyard occasionally hosts evening concerts in summer — worth checking locally before planning a standard daytime visit.

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ROUTE 03 • KYRENIA (GIRNE)

Harbour, castle *& sunset walk.*

Walking route · historic harbour

Kyrenia's harbour is the postcard image of Northern Cyprus, and it earns it. This route stays within a few hundred metres — castle, shipwreck, bazaar streets, and a sunset spot with no traffic in the frame.

1

Kyrenia Harbour

A horseshoe-shaped historic harbour lined with restored waterfront restaurants.

2

Kyrenia Castle

A Byzantine and Venetian fortress guarding the harbour entrance since medieval times.

3

Shipwreck Museum

Housed inside the castle, displaying the remains of a 4th-century BC Greek merchant ship.

4

Old town bazaar streets

Narrow lanes behind the harbour lined with small shops, tailors, and cafés.

5

Harbour sunset viewpoint

The western harbour wall, the best-placed spot in town to watch the sun go down over the water.

Practical info: the harbour walk is free, the castle and museum charge entry. Evenings get busy in summer. Parking near the harbour fills quickly — the eastern lots hold spaces longer.

LOCAL TIP

Park on the eastern side of the harbour. The western lots fill first once the sunset crowd arrives.

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ROUTE 04 • GÜZELYURT (MORPHOU)

Archaeology, nature *& orange town.*

Drive route · west coast

Güzelyurt is Cyprus's citrus capital, and it sits on top of two ancient city-kings. This route pairs the region's ruins with its groves — a day that moves between mosaic floors and orange trees within a few kilometres.

1

Güzelyurt Archaeology and Natural History Museum

Housed in a former monastery building, with regional archaeological and natural finds.

2

St. Mamas Church

A Byzantine church adjoining the museum, still active as a place of local worship.

3

Soli Ancient City

Ruins of an ancient city-kingdom, including mosaic floors and a restored amphitheatre.

4

Vouni Palace

Hilltop palace ruins with sweeping views over the west coastline below.

5

Güzelyurt orange groves

Citrus groves line the roads into town, giving Güzelyurt its long-standing nickname.

Practical info: the ruins involve uneven ground, sturdy shoes recommended. A car is needed to link the sites. Spring visits coincide with citrus blossom season.

LOCAL TIP

Ask at the museum desk about the current excavation area at Soli — active digs sometimes open extra sections that aren't signposted.

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Dipkarpaz village, wild donkeys & *Apostolos Andreas*.

Drive route · far east peninsula

The Karpaz Peninsula is the least developed stretch of the island — a long, narrow finger of land ending at a pilgrimage site. This route is the longest drive of the five, and the most remote.

1

Dipkarpaz Village

The easternmost village on the peninsula, home to a mixed Greek and Turkish Cypriot community.

2

Ayios Philon Church

A ruined Byzantine church beside the remains of an ancient harbour on the shoreline.

3

Wild donkey roaming area

Herds of free-roaming donkeys along the peninsula road, descendants of animals left behind decades ago.

4

Golden Beach

A long undeveloped sand beach and turtle nesting site, among the last wild beaches on the Mediterranean.

5

Apostolos Andreas Monastery

A pilgrimage site at the tip of the peninsula, held sacred by both Christian and Muslim visitors.

Practical info: fill up on fuel before entering the peninsula — options run out fast. Bring water. Some sections of road have loose gravel, drive slower than usual.

LOCAL TIP

The donkeys are wild — don't feed them by hand. Roadside vendors sell approved feed for exactly this reason.

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SUBMISSION

Five routes, one island, corner to corner.

Built for the Drive KKTC intern program — mapping Northern Cyprus one route at a time.

